

Diwan-i-Khas (Hall of Special Audience)

ديوان خاص

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Emperor Shah Jahan
- Built in: 1645 CE
- Cost: Not documented in available sources
- Built for: Private state affairs and meetings between the emperor and his most senior courtiers and dignitaries

2. Construction Details

- Location: South of Jahangir's Quadrangle
- Materials/technique: Not separately itemised in available sources beyond its general Shah Jahan-era marble-and-pietra-dura idiom shared with the Sheesh Mahal and Naulakha
- Craftsmen involved: Not documented
- Time taken: Not documented

3. Historical Background

- Access to the emperor here was itself a ceremony: elaborate court processions preceding an audience in this hall are recorded as lasting up to an hour before the emperor was actually approached - a detail that underlines how formal and hierarchical Mughal court protocol was, even for high-ranking nobles.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- Unlike the Diwan-i-Aam, which was about visibility and public spectacle, the Diwan-i-Khas was specifically about restricted access - only the most senior figures in the empire would ever be received here.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

A noble summoned to the Diwan-i-Khas in 1646 does not simply walk in - he waits through nearly an hour of ceremony, each stage signalling his rank and the emperor's, before finally standing in a private hall built specifically so that whatever is said there is heard by as few ears as possible.